

Influencing and Communication

Target Skill

communication skill: the ability to share information with other individuals

o b j e c t i v e s

To help build my *communication skill*, when studying this chapter, I will attempt to acquire:

1. An understanding of the relationship between influencing and emotional intelligence
2. An understanding of interpersonal communication
3. A knowledge of how to use feedback
4. An appreciation for the importance of nonverbal communication
5. Insights into formal organizational communication
6. An appreciation for the importance of the grapevine
7. Some hints on how to encourage organizational communication

CHALLENGE CASE

JETSTAR AIRWAYS SOARS ON COMMUNICATION

FOUNDED IN 2004, Jetstar Airways offers low fares to Australia and Singapore. Although owned by Qantas, Jetstar is managed and operated separately. Headed by CEO Bruce Buchanan, the airline has made a name for itself through its emphasis on operational excellence—including its attention to communication.

From the outset, Jetstar management worked to create an organizational culture that would be focused on providing excellent customer service. Managers knew that such a culture could exist only if the company's employees enjoyed their work and their affiliation with their employer. As a result, Jetstar leadership has been committed to creating the kind of organization employees are proud to be part of.

In model organizations, good communication dictates that employees never "read about their company in the media." In other words, all important news about an organization should come to employees from management, not from learning about it in a newspaper or on TV. To that end, Jetstar invested substantially in communication strategies that would ensure optimal communication. The airline's user-friendly company intranet, known as "dashboard," can be accessed remotely. An intranet that allowed remote access was key because, by the very nature of their work, airline employees are geographically dispersed. For example, Jetstar estimates that, on any given day, two-thirds of its 3,000 employees are working outside an office. That Jetstar's dashboard can be accessed remotely ensures that employees, regardless of their location, can obtain information where and when they need it.

Another feature of Jetstar's communication strategy is what management calls "the weekly wrap," a brief voicemail summary of the company's

week delivered from Buchanan or other member of senior leadership. Transmitted to Jetstar's employees via their cell phones, the weekly wrap ensures that news is communicated in a timely fashion, even to those whose jobs don't routinely involve computer use.

In fact, Jetstar's emphasis on connectivity extends beyond its workforce. The airline recently announced that it would offer iPad handsets on selected flights, giving passengers the ability to access music, movies, TV shows, games, and books enroute to their destination. If the trial program is successfully, says Buchanan, Jetstar will extend iPad connectivity to all flights.¹



■ The Jetstar A320, pictured here, provides comfortable leather seating and can carry 177 passengers within Australia and New Zealand.

EXPLORING YOUR MANAGEMENT SKILL

You can explore your level of communication skill **before** studying the chapter by completing the exercise “Exploring Your Management Skill: Part 1” on page 363 and **after**

studying this chapter by completing the exercise “Exploring Your Management Skill: Part 2” on page 364.

THE COMMUNICATION CHALLENGE

As described in the Challenge Case, Jetstar CEO Bruce Buchanan understands the importance of information flow within the organization. According to the case, Buchanan wants to build Jetstar into a high-performing organization that processes information efficiently. This chapter

emphasizes the challenge of improving communication within organizations such as Jetstar and offers some insight into how this challenge can be accomplished. The chapter is divided into two main parts: fundamentals of influencing and communication.

FUNDAMENTALS OF INFLUENCING

The four basic managerial functions—planning, organizing, influencing, and controlling—were introduced in Chapter 1. *Planning* and *organizing* have already been discussed; *influencing* is the third of these basic functions covered in this text. A definition of *influencing* and a discussion of the influencing subsystem follow.

Defining Influencing

Influencing is the process of guiding the activities of organization members in appropriate directions. *Appropriate directions*, of course, are those that lead to the attainment of management system objectives. Influencing involves focusing on organization members as people and dealing with such issues as morale, arbitration of conflicts, and the development of good working relationships.² It is a critical part of a manager’s job. In fact, the ability to influence others is a primary determinant of how successful a manager will be.³

The Influencing Subsystem

Like the planning and organizing functions, the influencing function can be viewed as a subsystem within the overall management system (see Figure 15.1). The primary purpose of the influencing subsystem, as already stated, is to enhance the attainment of management system objectives by guiding the activities of organization members in appropriate directions.⁴

FIGURE 15.1
Relationship between overall management system and influencing subsystem

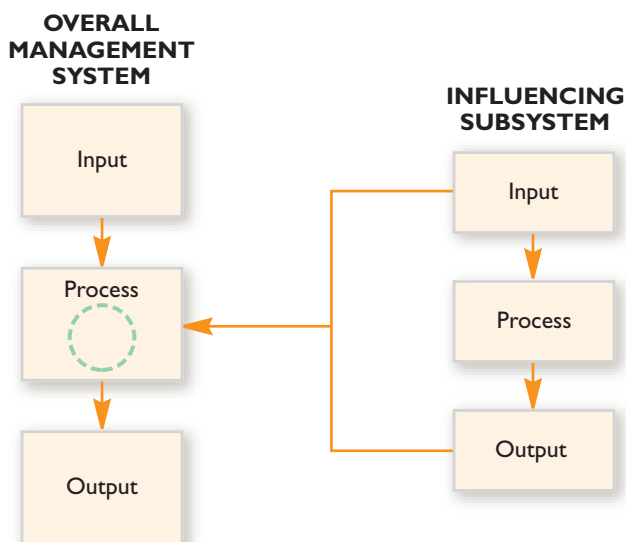


Figure 15.2 shows the constituents of the influencing subsystem. The input of this subsystem is composed of a portion of the total resources of the overall management system, and its output is appropriate organization member behavior. The process of the influencing subsystem involves the performance of six primary management activities:

1. Leading
2. Motivating
3. Considering groups
4. Communicating
5. Encouraging creativity and innovation
6. Building corporate culture

Managers transform a portion of organizational resources into appropriate organization member behavior mainly by performing these activities.

As Figure 15.2 shows, leading, motivating, considering groups, building corporate culture, communicating, and encouraging creativity and innovation are interrelated. Managers accomplish each of these influencing activities, to some extent, by communicating with organization members.

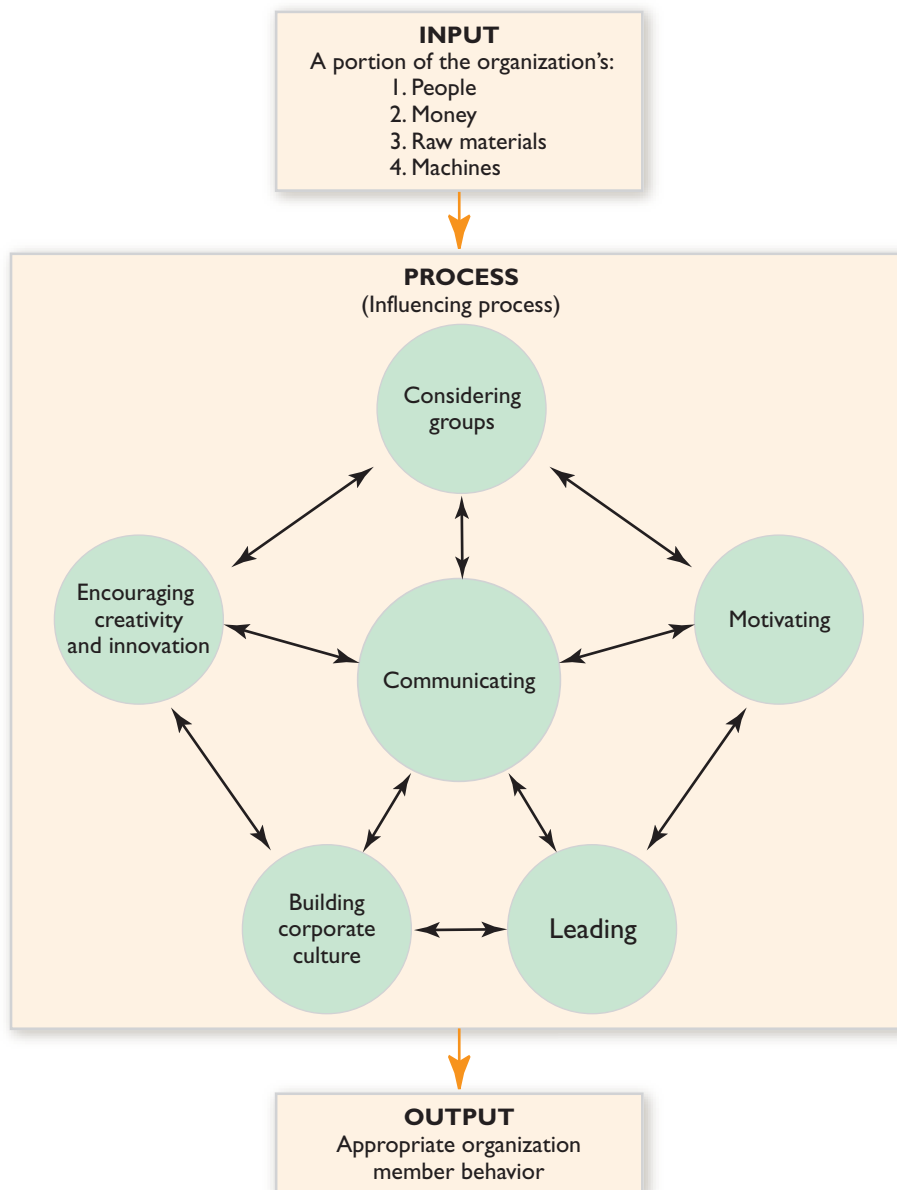


FIGURE 15.2
The influencing subsystem

For example, managers can only decide what kind of leader they need to be after they analyze the characteristics of the various groups with which they will interact and determine how those groups can best be motivated. Then, regardless of the leadership strategy they adopt, their leading, motivating, and working with groups, for example, will be accomplished—at least partly—through communication with other organization members.

In fact, all management activities are accomplished at least partly through communication or communication-related endeavors. Because communication is used repeatedly by managers, the ability to communicate is often referred to as the fundamental management skill.

A recent survey of chief executives supports this notion that communication is the fundamental management skill. The results, which appear in Table 15.1, show that CEOs ranked oral and written communication skills first (along with interpersonal skills) among those that should be taught to management students.

Emotional Intelligence

Earlier sections defined influencing and the influencing system. Overall, this influencing function of management focuses on guiding people to accomplish goals. Emotional intelligence, a concept developed by Daniel Goleman, is growing in popularity and prominence among both managers and management scholars. Overall, Goleman's concept enriches a discussion of influencing by focusing on specific skills that enable managers to become successful in guiding people toward goal accomplishment.⁵

TABLE 15.1 Chief Executives' Ranking of Skills They Believe Should Be Taught to Management Students

Rank*	Key Learning Area	Frequency Indicated
1	Oral and written communication skills	25
1	Interpersonal skills	25
3	Financial/managerial accounting skills	22
4	Ability to think, be analytical, and make decisions	20
5	Strategic planning and goal setting—concern for long-term performance	13
6	Motivation and commitment to the firm—giving 110 percent	12
7	Understanding of economics	11
8	Management information systems and computer applications	9
8	Thorough knowledge of your business, culture, and overall environment	9
8	Marketing concept (the customer is king) and skills	9
11	Integrity	7
11	Knowledge of yourself: setting long- and short-term career objectives	7
13	Leadership skills	6
13	Understanding of the functional areas of the business	6
15	Time management: setting priorities—how to work smart, not long or hard	1

*1 is most important.

Emotional intelligence is the capacity of people to recognize their own feelings and the feelings of others, to motivate themselves, and to manage their own emotions as well as the emotions in relationships with others. Overall, an individual's emotional intelligence is characterized by self-awareness, self-motivation, self-regulation, empathy for others, and adeptness in building relationships.

Studies indicate many interesting points regarding emotional intelligence. Some research indicates that managers with higher levels of emotional intelligence are likely to be successful because they are likely to build organization culture characterized by trust, learning, information-sharing, and desirable risk taking. Other studies reveal that managers with higher levels of emotional intelligence are more interpersonally effective when compared to managers with lower levels of emotional intelligence.⁶ Studies have also shown that managers with higher levels of emotional intelligence are likely to be more satisfied in their jobs than other managers, and employees who work for managers with higher levels of emotional intelligence are more satisfied with their jobs than employees who work for managers with lower levels of emotional intelligence. Ongoing studies reveal that a steady, five-year rise in emotional intelligence seems to be leveling off, perhaps implying that more training in this area needs to take place.⁷

In some ways, research in the area of emotional intelligence has produced somewhat puzzling results. On one hand, emotional intelligence research traditionally seems to indicate that managers with lower levels of emotional intelligence are likely to be relatively unsuccessful because they are less likely to produce a positive work culture.⁸ On the other hand, another study suggests that the farther an individual goes up the corporate ladder, the lower his or her emotional intelligence because some organizations promote employees based on their financial performance rather than people skills.⁹

At first glance, the close relationship between the traditional influencing function of management and Goleman's emotional intelligence may be hard to recognize. Upon inspecting the skills that Goleman outlines as being necessary to being an emotionally intelligent manager, however, the relationship becomes clearer. Figure 15.3 lists several of the skills of the emotionally intelligent manager. As you can see by inspecting Figure 15.3, the influencing section of this book and the concept of emotional intelligence both emphasize critical management concepts and skills in areas of motivation, communication, leadership, teamwork, creativity, and innovation—all important attributes in building positive psychological capital in an organization.¹⁰

Communication is discussed further in the rest of this chapter. Leading, motivating, and considering groups and teams, corporate culture, and creativity and innovation are discussed in Chapters 16, 17, 18, 19, and 20, respectively.

Emotionally intelligent managers:

1. Motivate others
2. Focus on personal and organizational achievement
3. Understand others
4. Communicate efficiently and effectively
5. Lead others
6. Build successful teams
7. Handle conflict appropriately
8. Change organizations appropriately
9. Manage diversity
10. Manage creativity and innovation

FIGURE 15.3

Ten Skills possessed by emotionally intelligent managers



Communication is the way we share thoughts and ideas with others.

COMMUNICATION

Communication is the process of sharing information with other individuals. Information, as used here, is any thought or idea that managers want to share with others. In general, communication involves the process of one person projecting a message to one or more other people, which results in everyone arriving at a common understanding of the message. Because communication is a commonly used management skill and ability and is often cited as the skill most responsible for a manager's success, prospective managers must learn how to communicate.¹¹ To help managers become better interpersonal communicators, new training techniques are constantly being developed and evaluated.¹²

The communication activities of managers generally involve interpersonal communication—sharing information with other organization members.¹³ The following sections feature both the general topic of interpersonal communication and the more specific topic of interpersonal communication in organizations.

Interpersonal Communication

To be a successful interpersonal communicator, a manager must understand the following:

1. How interpersonal communication works
2. The relationship between feedback and interpersonal communication
3. The importance of verbal versus nonverbal interpersonal communication

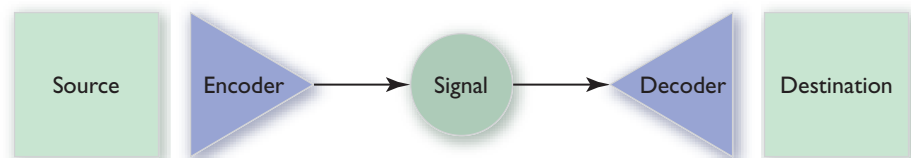
How Interpersonal Communication Works Interpersonal communication is the process of transmitting information to others.¹⁴ To be complete, the process must have the following three basic elements:¹⁵

1. **The source/encoder**—The **source/encoder** is the person in the interpersonal communication situation who originates and encodes information to be shared with others. Encoding is putting information into a form that can be received and understood by another individual. Putting one's thoughts into a letter is an example of encoding. Until information is encoded, it cannot be shared with others. (From here on, the *source/encoder* will be referred to simply as the *source*.)
2. **The signal**—Encoded information that the source intends to share constitutes a **message**. A message that has been transmitted from one person to another is called a **signal**.
3. **The decoder/destination**—The **decoder/destination** is the person or persons with whom the source is attempting to share information. This person receives the signal and decodes, or interprets, the message to determine its meaning. Decoding is the process of converting messages back into information. In all interpersonal communication situations, message meaning is a result of decoding. (From here on, the *decoder/destination* will be referred to simply as the *destination*.)

The classic work of Wilbur Schramm clarifies the role played by each of the three elements of the interpersonal communication process. As implied in Figure 15.4, the source determines what information to share, encodes this information in the form of a message, and then transmits the message as a signal to the destination. The destination decodes the transmitted message to determine its meaning and then responds accordingly.

FIGURE 15.4

Role of the source, signal, and destination in the communication process



A manager who desires to assign the performance of a certain task to a subordinate would use the communication process in the following way: First, the manager would determine exactly what task he or she wanted the subordinate to perform. Then the manager would encode and transmit a message to the subordinate that would accurately reflect this assignment. The message transmission itself could be as simple as the manager telling the subordinate what the new responsibilities include. Next, the subordinate would decode the message transmitted by the manager to ascertain its meaning and then respond to it appropriately.

Successful and Unsuccessful Interpersonal Communication **Successful communication** refers to an interpersonal communication situation in which the information the source intends to share with the destination and the meaning the destination derives from the transmitted message are the same. Conversely, **unsuccessful communication** is an interpersonal communication situation in which the information the source intends to share with the destination and the meaning the destination derives from the transmitted message are different.

To increase the probability that communication will be successful, the message must be encoded so the source's experience of the way a signal should be decoded is equivalent to the destination's experience of the way it should be decoded. If these experiences match up, the probability is high that the destination will interpret the signal as intended by the source. Figure 15.5 illustrates these overlapping fields of experience that ensure successful communication.

Barriers to Successful Interpersonal Communication Factors that decrease the probability that communication will be successful are called *communication barriers*. A clear understanding of these barriers will help managers maximize their communication success. The following sections discuss both communication macrobarriers and communication microbarriers.

MACROBARRIERS **Communication macrobarriers** are factors that hinder successful communication in a general communication situation.¹⁶ These factors relate primarily to the communication environment and the larger world in which communication takes place. Some common macrobarriers are the following:¹⁷

1. **The increasing need for information**—Because society is changing constantly and rapidly, individuals have a greater and greater need for information. This growing need tends to overload communication networks, thereby distorting communication. To minimize the effects of this barrier, managers should take steps to ensure that organization members are not overloaded with information. Only information critical to the performance of their jobs should be transmitted to them.

The White House is an example of an organization that regularly faces increasing needs for information from a variety of audiences, including the American public. After an evaluation of President Barack Obama's first year in office, the White House staff decided to retool elements of its communication strategy to better meet increasing needs for information that others might have. As a result of this evaluation, the White House staff decided to take specific steps aimed at better meeting such increasing needs—for example, staffers will be more aggressive in taking initiative in sending out information before it's requested. In addition, they will provide speedier, more exact responses to information requests and help the President to be more efficient when communicating with others.¹⁸ ■

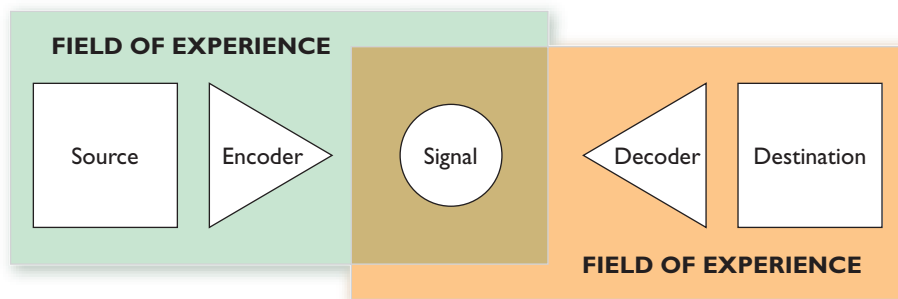
how managers do it

Dealing with Increasing Needs for Information at the White House

2. **The need for increasingly complex information**—Because of today's rapid technological advances, most people are confronted with complex communication situations in their everyday lives. If managers take steps to emphasize simplicity in communication, the effects of this barrier can be lessened. Furnishing organization members with adequate training to deal with more technical areas is another strategy for overcoming this barrier.

FIGURE 15.5

Overlapping fields of experience that ensure successful communication



3. **The reality that people in the United States are increasingly coming into contact with people who use languages other than English**—As U.S. business becomes more international in scope, and as organization members travel more frequently, the need to know languages other than English increases. The potential communication barrier of this multilanguage situation is obvious. Moreover, people who deal with foreigners need to be familiar not only with their languages, but also with their cultures. Formal knowledge of a foreign language is of little value unless the individual knows which words, phrases, and actions are culturally acceptable.¹⁹
4. **The constant need to learn new concepts cuts down on the time available for communication**—Many managers feel pressured to learn new and important concepts that they did not have to know in the past. Learning about the intricacies of international business or computer usage, for example, takes up significant amounts of managerial time. Many managers also find that the increased demands that training employees makes on their time leaves them with less time for communicating with other organization members.

MICROBARRIERS A **communication microbarrier** is a factor that hinders successful communication in a specific communication situation.²⁰ These factors relate directly to such variables as the communication message, the source, and the destination. Among the microbarriers are the following:²¹

1. **The source's view of the destination**—The source in any communication situation has a tendency to view the destination in a specific way, and this view influences the messages sent. For example, individuals usually speak differently to people they think are informed about a subject than to those they believe are uninformed. The destination can sense the source's attitudes, which often block successful communication. Managers should keep an open mind about the people with whom they communicate and be careful not to imply negative attitudes through their communication behaviors. Figure 15.6 lists several examples of negative attitudes or stereotypes that managers in our modern society might possess regarding various types of employees. If managers possess such negative feelings about employees, the feelings will inevitably negatively impact the manner in which managers communicate to those employees and ultimately limit organizational success. Such negative attitudes or stereotypes have no place in the world of modern management.
2. **Message interference**—Stimuli that compete with the communication message for the attention of the destination are called **message interference**, or noise. An instance of message interference is a manager talking to an office worker while the worker is trying to input

FIGURE 15.6

Examples of managers' potentially negative attitudes toward employees

Employee Type	Possible Negative Attitude Held
Women	Women have weak math ability
Senior citizens	Older people have bad memory
Gay men	Gay men are dangerous to young children
Whites	Whites are racists
Men	Men are less capable than women in dealing with emotional issues
Black men	Black men are more coordinated than white men

Source: This figure is based on Loriann Roberson and Carol T. Kulik, "Stereotype Threat at Work," *Academy of Management Perspectives* 21, no. 2 (May 2007): 28–29.

data into a computer. The inputting of data is message interference here because it is competing with the manager's communication message. Managers should attempt to communicate only when they have the total attention of the individuals with whom they wish to share information.

3. **The destination's view of the source**—Certain attitudes of the destination toward the source can also hinder successful communication. If, for example, a destination believes the source has little credibility in the area about which the source is communicating, the destination may filter out much of the source's message and pay only slight attention to that part of the message actually received. Managers should attempt to consider the worth of messages transmitted to them independently of their personal attitudes toward the source. Many valuable ideas will escape them if they allow their personal feelings toward others to influence which messages they attend to.
4. **Perception**—**Perception** is an individual's interpretation of a message. Different individuals may perceive the same message in different ways. The two primary factors that influence how a stimulus is perceived are the destination's education level and the destination's amount of experience. To minimize the negative effects of this perceptual factor on interpersonal communication, managers should try to send messages with precise meanings. Ambiguous words generally tend to magnify negative perceptions. What's more, trite or insincere messages are easy for employees to recognize.²²
5. **Multimeaning words**—Because many words in the English language have several meanings, a destination may have difficulty deciding which meaning should be attached to the words of a message. A manager should not assume that a word means the same thing to all the people who use it.

A classic study by Lydia Strong substantiates this point. Strong concluded that for the 500 most common words in our language, there are 4,070 different dictionary definitions. On the average, each of these words has more than eight usages. The word *run* is an example:²³

Babe Ruth scored a run.
Did you ever see Jesse Owens run?
I have a run in my stocking.
There is a fine run of salmon this year.
Are you going to run this company or am I?
You have the run of the place.
What headline do you want to run?
There was a run on the bank today.
Did he run the ship aground?
I have to run (drive the car) downtown.
Who will run for president this year?
Joe flies the New York–Chicago run twice a week.
You know the kind of people they run around with.
The apples run large this year.
Please run my bathwater.

When encoding information, managers should be careful to define the terms they are using whenever possible, never use obscure meanings for words when designing messages, and strive to use words in the same way their destination uses them.

Feedback and Interpersonal Communication **Feedback** is the destination's reaction to a message. Feedback can be used by the source to ensure successful communication. For example, if the destination's message reaction is inappropriate, the source can conclude that communication was unsuccessful and that another message should be transmitted. If the destination's message reaction is appropriate, the source can conclude that communication was successful (assuming, of course, that the appropriate reaction did not happen merely by chance). Because of its potentially high value, managers should encourage feedback whenever possible and evaluate it carefully.²⁴

Gathering and Using Feedback Feedback can be either verbal or nonverbal.²⁵ To gather verbal feedback, the source can simply ask the destination pertinent message-related questions; the destination's answers should indicate whether the message was perceived as intended. To gather

nonverbal feedback, the source can observe the destination's nonverbal response to a message.²⁶ Say a manager has transmitted a message to a subordinate specifying new steps that must be taken in the normal performance of the subordinate's job. The subordinate's failure to follow the steps accurately constitutes nonverbal feedback telling the manager that the initial message needs to be clarified.

If managers discover their communication effectiveness is relatively low over an extended period of time, they should assess the situation to determine how to improve their communication skills. It may be that their vocabulary is confusing to their destinations. For example, a study conducted by Group Attitudes Corporation found that when managers used certain words repeatedly in communicating with steelworkers, the steelworkers usually became confused.²⁷ Among the words causing confusion were *accrue*, *contemplate*, *designate*, *detriment*, *magnitude*, and *subsequently*.

Achieving Communication Effectiveness In general, managers can sharpen their communication skills by adhering to the following "10 commandments of good communication" as closely as possible:²⁸

1. **Seek to clarify your ideas before communicating**—The more systematically you analyze the problem or idea to be communicated, the clearer it becomes. This is the first step toward effective communication. Many communications fail because of inadequate planning. Good planning must consider the goals and attitudes of those who will receive the communication and those who will be affected by it.
2. **Examine the true purpose of each communication**—Before you communicate, ask yourself what you really want to accomplish with your message—obtain information, initiate action, change another person's attitude? Identify your most important goal and then adapt your language, tone, and total approach to serve that specific objective. Don't try to accomplish too much with each communication. The sharper the focus of your message, the greater its chances of success.
3. **Consider the total physical and human setting whenever you communicate**—Meaning and intent are conveyed by more than words alone. Many other factors influence the overall impact of a communication, and managers must be sensitive to the total setting in which they communicate. Consider, for example, your sense of timing, or the circumstances under which you make an announcement or render a decision; the physical setting; whether you communicate in private or otherwise, for example, the social climate that pervades work relationships within your company or department and sets the tone of its communications; and custom and practice, or the degree to which your communication conforms to, or departs from, the expectations of your audience. Be constantly aware of the total setting in which you communicate. Like all living things, communication must be capable of adapting to its environment.
4. **Consult with others, when appropriate, in planning communications**—Frequently, it is desirable or necessary to seek the participation of others in planning a communication or in developing the facts on which to base the communication. Such consultation often lends additional insight and objectivity to your message. Moreover, those who have helped you plan your communication will give it their active support.
5. **Be mindful of the overtones while you communicate rather than merely the basic content of your message**—Your tone of voice, your expression, your apparent receptiveness to the responses of others—all have a significant effect on those you wish to reach. Frequently overlooked, these subtleties of communication often affect a listener's reaction to a message even more than its basic content. Similarly, your choice of language—particularly your awareness of the fine shades of meaning and emotion in the words you use—predetermines, in large part, the reactions of your listeners.
6. **Take the opportunity, when it arises, to convey something of help or value to the receiver**—Consideration of the other person's interests and needs—trying to look at things from the other person's point of view—frequently points out opportunities to convey something of immediate benefit or long-range value to the other person. Subordinates are most responsive to managers whose messages take the subordinates' interests into account.
7. **Follow up your communication**—Your best efforts at communication may be wasted, and you may never know whether you have succeeded in expressing your true meaning and intent, if you do not follow up and evaluate how well your message was received. You can do this by asking questions, by

encouraging the receiver to express his or her reactions, by following up on contacts, and by subsequently reviewing performance. Make certain that you get feedback for every important communication so that complete understanding and appropriate action result.

8. **Communicate for tomorrow as well as today**—Even though communications may be aimed primarily at meeting the demands of an immediate situation, they must be planned with the past in mind if they are to be viewed as consistent by the receiver. Most importantly, however, communications must be consistent with long-range interests and goals. For example, it is not easy to communicate frankly on such matters as poor performance or the shortcomings of a loyal subordinate, but postponing disagreeable communications makes these matters more difficult in the long run and is actually unfair to your subordinates and your company.
9. **Be sure your actions support your communications**—In the final analysis, the most persuasive kind of communication is not what you say, but what you do. When your actions or attitudes contradict your words, others tend to discount what you have said. For every manager, good supervisory practices—such as clear assignment of responsibility and authority, fair rewards for effort, and sound policy enforcement—communicate more than all the gifts of oratory.
10. **Last, but by no means least, seek not only to be understood, but also to understand—be a good listener**—When you start talking, you often cease to listen, or at least to be attuned to the other person's unspoken reactions and attitudes. Even more serious is the occasional inattentiveness you may be guilty of when others are attempting to communicate with you. Listening is one of the most important, most difficult, and most neglected skills in communication. It demands that you concentrate, not only on the explicit meanings another person is expressing, but also on the implicit meanings, unspoken words, and undertones that may be far more significant.



Nonverbal communication uses gestures, tone, and facial expression to convey information. What do you think Donald Trump is communicating?

Verbal and Nonverbal Interpersonal Communication Interpersonal communication is generally divided into two types: verbal and nonverbal. Up to this point, the chapter has emphasized **verbal communication**—communication that uses either spoken or written words to share information with others.

Nonverbal communication is the sharing of information without using words to encode thoughts. Factors commonly used to encode thoughts in nonverbal communication are gestures, vocal tones, and facial expressions.²⁹ In most interpersonal communication, verbal and nonverbal communications are not mutually exclusive. Instead, the destination's interpretation of a message is generally based both on the words contained in the message and on such nonverbal factors as the source's gestures and facial expressions.

The Importance of Nonverbal Communication In an interpersonal communication situation in which both verbal and nonverbal factors are present, nonverbal factors may have more influence on the total effect of the message.³⁰ Over two decades ago, Albert Mehrabian developed the following formula to show the relative contributions of verbal and nonverbal factors to the total effect of a message: Total message impact = .07 words + .38 vocal tones + .55 facial expressions. Other nonverbal factors besides vocal tones that can influence the effect of a verbal message are facial expressions, gestures, gender, and dress. Managers who are aware of this great potential influence of nonverbal factors on the effect of their communications will use nonverbal message ingredients to complement their verbal message ingredients whenever possible.³¹

Nonverbal messages can also be used to add content to verbal messages. For instance, a head might be nodded or a voice toned to show either agreement or disagreement.

Managers must be especially careful when they are communicating that verbal and nonverbal factors do not present contradictory messages. For example, if the words of a message express approval while the nonverbal factors express disapproval, the result will be message ambiguity that leaves the destination frustrated.

Managers who are able to communicate successfully through a blend of verbal and nonverbal communication are critical to the success of virtually every organization. In fact, a recent survey of corporate recruiters across the United States, commissioned by the Darden Graduate School



Announcement of a company's financial performance to employees by a CEO is an example of downward organizational communication. Here Anheuser-Busch InBev Chief Executive Carlos Brito presents the company's financial results.

of Business at the University of Virginia, revealed that the skill organizations most seek in prospective employees is facility at verbal and nonverbal communication.

Interpersonal Communication in Organizations

To be effective communicators, managers must understand not only general interpersonal communication concepts, but also the characteristics of interpersonal communication within organizations, or **organizational communication**. Organizational communication directly relates to the goals, functions, and structure of human organizations.³² To a major extent, organizational success is determined by the effectiveness of organizational communication.³³

Although organizational communication was frequently referred to by early management writers, the topic did not receive systematic study and attention until after World War II. From World War II through the 1950s, the discipline of organizational communication made significant advances in such areas as mathematical communication theory and behavioral communication theory, and the emphasis on organizational communication has grown stronger in colleges of business throughout the nation since the 1970s.³⁴ The following sections focus on three fundamental organizational communication topics: (1) formal organizational communication, (2) informal organizational communication, and (3) the encouragement of formal organizational communication.

Formal Organizational Communication In general, organizational communication that follows the lines of the organization chart is called **formal organizational communication**.³⁵ As discussed in Chapter 11, the organization chart depicts relationships of people and jobs and shows the formal channels of communication among them.

Types of Formal Organizational Communication The three basic types of formal organizational communication are downward, upward, and lateral.

1. **Downward organizational communication** is communication that flows from any point on an organization chart downward to another point on the organization chart. This type of formal organizational communication relates primarily to the direction and control of employees. Job-related information that focuses on what activities are required, when they should be performed, and how they should be coordinated with other activities within the organization must be transmitted to employees. This downward communication typically includes a statement of organizational philosophy, management system objectives, position descriptions, and other written information relating to the importance, rationale, and interrelationships of various departments.

how managers do it

Podcasts Enhance Downward Communication at Ericsson

Downward communication can refer to the messages that management delivers to employees. Such communication can have a significant impact on an organization's productivity and, hence, its profitability.

Thanks to technological advances, many organizations are able to leverage technology to enhance the communication that flows from management to the workforce. Consider, for example, Ericsson, a leading manufacturer of telecommunication equipment and a service provider. With a geographically dispersed workforce, Ericsson leadership sought an efficient way to communicate company news quickly and uniformly throughout the organization. Ericsson turned to audio podcasting as a solution to delivering up-to-the-minute information to its over 75,000 employees in the field. Podcasts have helped the company boost the effectiveness of its salesforce.³⁶ ■

2. **Upward organizational communication** is communication that flows from any point on an organization chart upward to another point on the organization chart.³⁷ This type of organizational communication contains primarily the information managers need to evaluate

the organizational area for which they are responsible and to determine whether something is going wrong within it. Techniques that managers commonly use to encourage upward organizational communication are informal discussions with employees, attitude surveys, the development and use of grievance procedures, suggestion systems, and an “open door” policy that invites employees to come in whenever they would like to talk to management.³⁸ Organizational modifications based on the feedback provided by upward organizational communication will enable a company to be more successful in the future.

3. **Lateral organizational communication** is communication that flows from any point on an organization chart horizontally to another point on the organization chart. Communication that flows across the organization usually focuses on coordinating the activities of various departments and developing new plans for future operating periods. Within the organization, all departments are related to all other departments. Only through lateral communication can these departmental relationships be coordinated well enough to enhance the attainment of management system objectives.

Patterns of Formal Organizational Communication By its very nature, organizational communication creates patterns of communication among organization members. These patterns evolve from the repeated occurrence of various serial transmissions of information. According to Haney, a **serial transmission** involves passing information from one individual to another in a series. It occurs under the following circumstances:³⁹

A communicates a message to B; B then communicates A’s message (or rather his or her interpretation of A’s message) to C; C then communicates his or her interpretation of B’s interpretation of A’s message to D; and so on. The originator and the ultimate recipient of the message are separated by middle people.

One obvious weakness of a serial transmission is that messages tend to become distorted as the length of the series increases. Research has shown that message details may be omitted, altered, or added in a serial transmission.

The potential inaccuracy of transmitted messages is not the only weakness of serial transmissions. A classic article by Alex Bavelas and Dermot Barrett⁴⁰ makes the case that serial transmissions can also influence morale, the emergence of a leader, the degree to which individuals involved in the transmissions are organized, and their efficiency. Three basic organizational communication patterns and the corresponding effects on the variables just mentioned are shown in Figure 15.7.

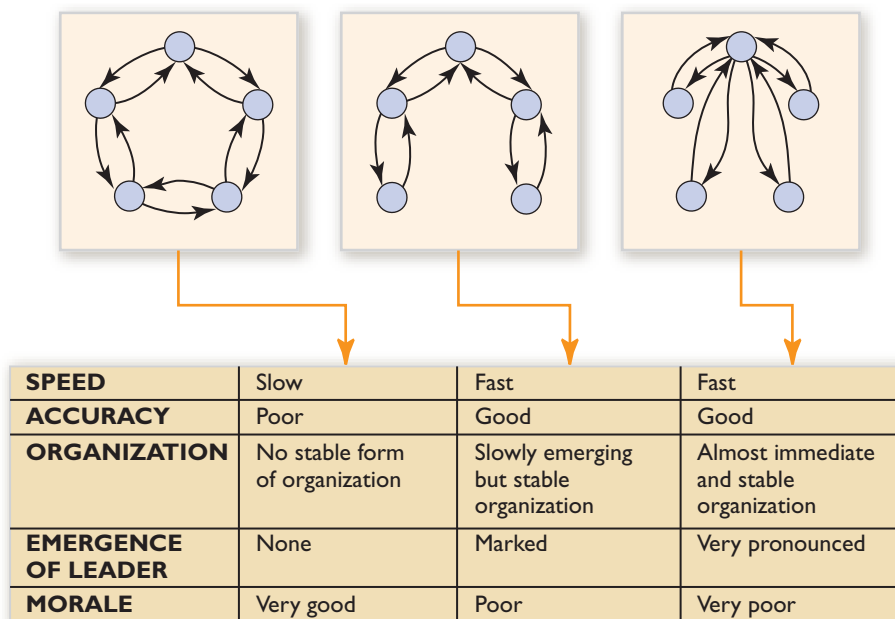


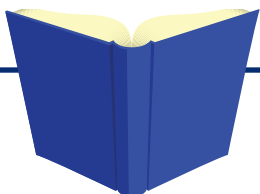
FIGURE 15.7
Comparison of three patterns of organizational communication based on the variables of speed, accuracy, organization, emergence of leader, and morale

Informal Organizational Communication Informal organizational communication is organizational communication that does not follow the lines of the organization chart.⁴¹ Instead, this type of communication typically follows the pattern of personal relationships among organization members: One friend communicates with another friend, regardless of their relative positions on the organization chart. Informal organizational communication networks generally exist because organization members have a desire for information that is not furnished through formal organizational communication.⁴² In times of economic downturn, informal communication tends to increase because organization members are scavenging for information from almost anyone regarding how well the organization is doing and if job cutbacks seem eminent.⁴³

To manage informal organizational communication appropriately, managers must strive to understand how this informal network operates in their organizations. For example, at Steelcase in Grand Rapids, Michigan, management conducted a study to better understand the informal communication that went on within the company. The study yielded valuable information: for instance, at Steelcase the days of standing around the water cooler to exchange the latest organizational gossip or company news may be over. Only 1 percent of Steelcase employees go to the cooler for more than water. At Steelcase, informal communication conversations are more likely to take place in the office kitchen, at a co-worker's desk, or through e-mail.⁴⁴

Patterns of Informal Organizational Communication The informal organizational communication network, or **grapevine**, has three main characteristics:

1. It springs up and is used irregularly within the organization.
2. It is not controlled by top executives, who may not even be able to influence it.
3. It exists largely to serve the self-interests of the people within it.



class discussion highlight

MODERN RESEARCH AND COMMUNICATION SKILL

The Impact of Diversity on Organizational Communication in Foreign Subsidiaries

Various attributes of people can affect the interpersonal communication process in organizations. This highlight focuses on a research study by Vesa Peltokorpi that explores the relationship between employee diversity and interpersonal communication in organizations.

The study focused on nine different sales subsidiaries in Japan owned by different Nordic companies. Nordic refers to the northwestern European countries of Norway, Sweden, Denmark, Iceland, and Finland. For the study, a survey was specially designed to see whether individuals from diverse cultural backgrounds within a company were reluctant to communicate with one another. Employees in all subsidiaries, including Nordic expatriates, were analyzed together. Overall,

110 employees from the nine subsidiaries participated in the study. All subjects were engaged in sales activities, but the industries in which they operated varied.

The researchers wanted to see whether diversity variables—such as differences in employee ages, gender, race, education, and work values—would encourage or discourage communication among the employees in organizations. The researcher predicted that differences in characteristics would actually discourage people from communicating with one another. Do you think results of the study were consistent with the prediction? Why? Why not? How would you use your expected findings to increase your communication skill as a manager?

Source: Vesa Peltokorpi, "The Impact of Relational Diversity and Socio-Cultural Context on Interpersonal Communication: Nordic Subsidiaries in Japan," *Asian Business & Management* 5, no. 3 (September 2006): 333–356.

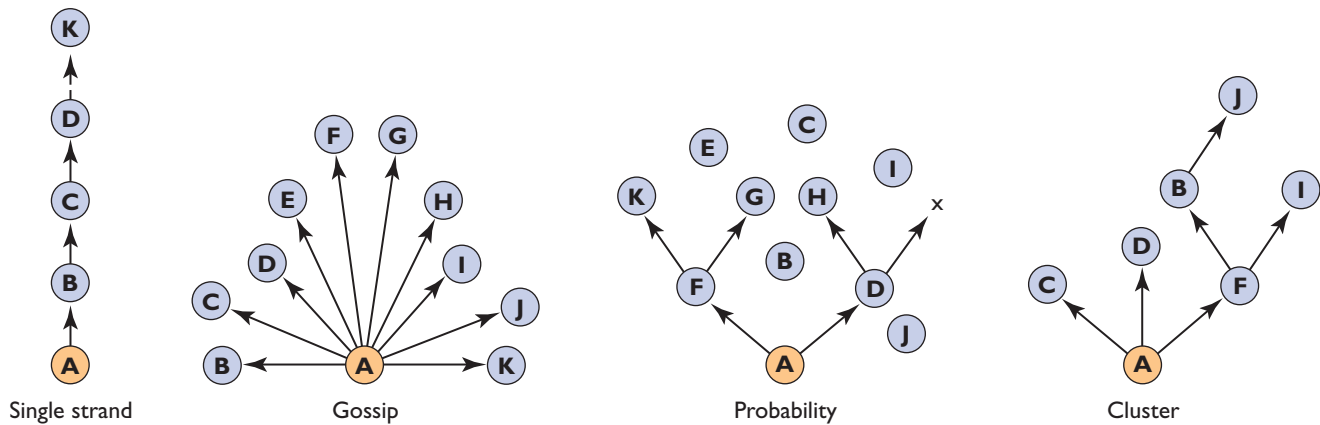


FIGURE 15.8 Four types of organizational grapevines

Understanding the grapevine is a prerequisite for a complete understanding of organizational communication. It has been estimated that 70 percent of all communication in organizations flows along the organizational grapevine. Not only do grapevines carry great amounts of communication, but they carry it at rapid speeds. Employees commonly cite the company grapevine as the most reliable and credible source of information about company events.⁴⁵

Like formal organizational communication, informal organizational communication uses serial transmissions. The difference is that it is more difficult for managers to identify organization members involved in these transmissions than members of the formal communication network. A classic article by Keith Davis that appeared in the *Harvard Business Review* has been a significant help to managers in understanding how organizational grapevines spring up and operate. Figure 15.8 sketches the four most common grapevine patterns as outlined by Davis. They are as follows:⁴⁶

1. **The single-strand grapevine**—A tells B, who tells C, who tells D, and so on. This type of grapevine tends to distort messages more than any other.
2. **The gossip grapevine**—A informs everyone else on the grapevine.
3. **The probability grapevine**—A communicates randomly—for example, to F and D. F and D then continue to inform other grapevine members in the same way.
4. **The cluster grapevine**—A selects and tells C, D, and F. F selects and tells I and B, and B selects and tells J. Information in this grapevine travels only to selected individuals.

DEALING WITH GRAPEVINES Clearly, grapevines are a factor managers must deal with because they can, and often do, generate rumors that are detrimental to organizational success. Exactly how individual managers should deal with the grapevine, of course, depends on the specific organizational situation in which they find themselves. Managers can use grapevines advantageously to maximize information flow to employees. When employees have what they view as sufficient organizational information, it seems to build their sense of belonging to the organization and their level of productivity. Some writers even argue that managers should encourage the development of grapevines and strive to become grapevine members to gain feedback that could be valuable in improving the organization.⁴⁷

Encouraging Formal Organizational Communication Because the organization acts only in the way its organizational communication directs it to act, organizational communication is often called the nervous system of the organization. Formal organizational communication is generally the more important type of communication within an organization, so managers should encourage its free flow.

One strategy for promoting formal organizational communication is to listen attentively to messages that come through formal channels. Listening shows organization members that the manager is interested in what subordinates have to say and encourages them to use formal communication channels in subsequent situations. Table 15.2 presents some general guidelines for listening well.

TABLE 15.2 Ten Commandments for Good Listening

1. <i>Stop talking!</i>
You cannot listen if you are talking.
Polonius (<i>Hamlet</i>): "Give every man thine ear, but few thy voice."
2. <i>Put the talker at ease.</i>
Help the talker feel free to talk.
This is often called establishing a permissive environment.
3. <i>Show the talker that you want to listen.</i>
Look and act interested. Do not read your mail while he or she talks.
Listen to understand rather than to oppose.
4. <i>Remove distractions.</i>
Do not doodle, tap, or shuffle papers.
Will it be quieter if you shut the door?
5. <i>Empathize with the talker.</i>
Try to put yourself in the talker's place so that you can see his or her point of view.
6. <i>Be patient.</i>
Allow plenty of time. Do not interrupt the talker.
Do not start for the door to walk away.
7. <i>Hold your temper.</i>
An angry person gets the wrong meaning from words.
8. <i>Go easy on argument and criticism.</i>
This puts the talker on the defensive. He or she may "clam up" or get angry.
Do not argue: even if you win, you lose.
9. <i>Ask questions.</i>
This encourages the talker and shows you are listening.
It helps to develop points further.
10. <i>Stop talking!</i>
This is the first and last commandment, because all other commandments depend on it. You just can't do a good listening job while you are talking. Nature gave us two ears but only one tongue, which is a gentle hint that we should listen more than we talk.

how managers do it

Increasing Listening at McDonald's

The United Kingdom segment of McDonald's offers a useful example on how to increase listening within a company. When faced with meeting a number of daunting organizational challenges, U.K. CEO Peter Beresford instituted a program called *Listening Campaign*. Under the program, Beresford and his staff had face-to-face meetings with various stakeholder groups including staff, customers, and investors. The purpose: to listen to stakeholders and gather input regarding the challenges Beresford faced. According to Beresford, the success of *Listening Campaign* was undeniable. Through listening, he achieved numerous benefits, including building more effective work teams, identifying organizational problems and their solutions, and implementing sound problem solutions.⁴⁸ ■

Some other strategies to encourage the flow of formal organizational communication are as follows:

- Support the flow of clear and concise statements through formal communication channels. Receiving an ambiguous message through a formal organizational communication channel can discourage employees from using that channel again.
- Take care to ensure all organization members have free access to formal communication channels. Obviously, organization members cannot communicate formally within the organization if they don't have access to the formal communication network.
- Assign specific communication responsibilities to staff personnel who could be of enormous help to line personnel in spreading important information throughout the organization.
- Make sure leaders sending messages are trusted by the workforce. Interestingly, a recent study reported that less than 40 percent of employees have trust or confidence in their senior leadership.⁴⁹

CHALLENGE CASE SUMMARY

One of Jetstar CEO Bruce Buchanan's primary responsibilities is *influencing*—guiding the activities of Jetstar employees to enhance the accomplishment of organizational objectives. Buchanan could perform this function by *leading* such individuals as division managers or perhaps corporate market research staff, by *motivating* them to do better jobs, by working well with various *groups* of employees, *encouraging creativity and innovation*, and by *communicating* successfully with employees.

Of all of these influencing activities, however, communication should be especially important to Buchanan. Communication is the main tool through which Buchanan and his leadership team should, at least to some extent, accomplish their duties. As an example in the Challenge Case, through the weekly wrap voicemail communications Buchanan and his team spread the message that Jetstar needs to focus on customer needs when delivering service. Almost any impact Buchanan plans to exert on Jetstar (planning, organizing, or controlling) will require him to communicate with other Jetstar employees. In essence, Buchanan must be a good communicator if he is to be a successful manager at Jetstar.

In discussing Bruce Buchanan's ability to communicate, we are actually discussing his ability to share ideas with other Jetstar employees. For Buchanan to be a successful communicator, he must concentrate on the three essential elements of the communication process. The first element is the source—the individual who wishes to share information with another. In this case, the source is Buchanan. The second element is the signal—the message transmitted by Buchanan. The third element is the destination—the Jetstar employee with whom Buchanan wishes to share information. Buchanan should communicate with Jetstar employees by determining what information he wants to share, encoding the information, and then transmitting the message. The subordinates would then interpret the message and respond accordingly. Buchanan's communication

would be successful if subordinates interpreted messages as he intended.

If Buchanan is to be a successful communicator, he must minimize the impact of numerous communication barriers. These barriers include:

1. Jetstar employees need to have more information and more complex information to do their jobs
2. Message interference
3. Buchanan's view of the destination as well as the destination's view of Buchanan
4. The perceptual process of the people involved in the communication attempt
5. Multimeaning words

The employees' reactions to Buchanan's messages can provide Buchanan with perhaps his most useful tool in making communication successful—feedback. When feedback does not seem appropriate, Buchanan should transmit another message to clarify the meaning of his first message. He must be alert to both verbal and nonverbal feedback. Over time, if feedback indicates that Buchanan is a relatively unsuccessful communicator, he should analyze his situation carefully to improve his communication effectiveness. He might find, for instance, that he is using vocabulary that is generally inappropriate for certain employees or that he is not following one or more of the 10 commandments of good communication.

In addition, Buchanan must remember that he can communicate to others without using words. His facial expressions, gestures, and even the tone of his voice say things to people. Most of Buchanan's communication situations involve both verbal and nonverbal messages to Jetstar employees. Because the impact of a message may be generated mostly by its nonverbal components, Buchanan must be certain that his nonverbal messages complement his verbal messages. By delivering the weekly wrap mentioned in the Challenge Case to all employees'

cell phones, for example, Buchanan nonverbally conveyed the importance of delivering timely communication to all of Jetstar's employees, regardless of their location.

As chairman at Jetstar, Bruce Buchanan must strive to understand the intricacies of organizational communication—interpersonal communication as it takes place within the organization. The success of organizational communication at Jetstar is an important factor in determining the company's level of success. Buchanan can communicate with his people in two basic ways: formally and informally.

In general, Buchanan's formal communication should follow the lines on the organization chart. Buchanan can communicate downward to, for example, divisional managers or upward to, for example, Jetstar's board of directors. Buchanan's downward communication will commonly focus on the activities subordinates are performing. His upward communication will usually illustrate how the company is performing. Because Buchanan is CEO and has no one at the same level within the organization, he would not communicate laterally. He should, however, take steps to ensure that lateral communication does occur at other organizational levels to enhance planning and coordination at Jetstar.

It is certain that an extensive grapevine exists at Jetstar. Although the company grapevine must be dealt with, Buchanan may not be able to influence it significantly. Jetstar employees, like employees at any company, typically are involved in grapevines for self-interest and because the formal organization has not furnished them with the information they believe they need.

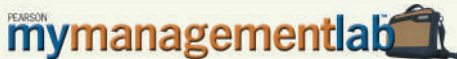
By developing various social relationships, Buchanan could conceivably become part of the grapevine and obtain valuable feedback from it. Also, because grapevines generate rumors that could have a detrimental effect on Jetstar's success, Buchanan should try to ensure that personnel are given all the information they need to do their jobs well through formal organizational communication, thereby reducing the need for a grapevine.

Because formal organizational communication is vitally important to Jetstar, Buchanan should try to encourage its flow as much as possible. By listening intently to messages that come to him over formal channels, supporting the flow of clear messages, and making sure that all Jetstar employees have access to these channels, Buchanan can make sure Jetstar's communication is the best it can be.

MANAGEMENT SKILL ACTIVITIES

This section is specially designed to help you develop communication skill. An individual's communication skill is based on an understanding of communication concepts and the ability to apply those concepts in management situations. The following activities are designed both to heighten your understanding of communication fundamentals and to develop your ability to apply those concepts in various management situations.

UNDERSTANDING COMMUNICATION CONCEPTS



To check your understanding and to practice using the concepts in this chapter, go to www.mymanagementlab.com and explore the material associated with Chapter 15.

Know Key Terms

Understanding the following key terms is critical to your understanding of chapter material. Define each of these terms. Refer to the page(s) referenced after a term to check your definition or to gain further insight regarding the term.

influencing **346**
 emotional intelligence **349**
 communication **350**
 source/encoder **350**
 message **350**
 signal **350**
 decoder/destination **350**
 successful communication **351**

unsuccessful communication **351**
 communication macrobarrier **351**
 communication microbarrier **352**
 message interference **352**
 perception **353**
 feedback **353**
 verbal communication **355**
 nonverbal communication **355**

organizational communication **356**
 formal organizational
 communication **356**
 serial transmission **357**
 informal organizational
 communication **358**
 grapevine **358**

Know How Management Concepts Relate

This section is comprised of activities that will sharpen your understanding of communication concepts. Answer essay questions as completely as possible. Also, remember that

additional true/false and multiple choice questions appear online at MyManagementLab.com to help you further refine your understanding of communication.

1. Discuss the significance of “field of experience” in communication.
2. What is feedback and how should managers use it when communicating?
3. How can managers encourage the flow of formal communication in organizations?
4. What is “emotional intelligence” and how does it relate to influencing people in organizations?
5. Draw three types of organizational grapevines and explain how communication effectiveness might be impacted by each type.

DEVELOPING MANAGEMENT SKILLS

Learning activities in this section are aimed at helping you to develop communication skill. Learning activities include Exploring Your Management Skill: Parts 1 & 2, Experiential Exercises, Cases, and a VideoNet Exercise.

Exploring Your Management Skill: Part 1

Before studying this chapter, respond to the following questions regarding the type of advice you would give to Bruce Buchanan, the CEO referenced in the Challenge Case. Then address the concerning communication challenges that he faces within Jetstar. You are not expected to be a communication expert at this point. Answering the questions now can help you focus on important points when you study the chapter. Also, answering the questions again after you study the chapter will give you an idea of how much you have learned.

Record your answers here or go to MyManagementLab.com. Recording your answers in MyManagementLab will allow you to get immediate results and see how your score compares to your classmates. If you answer the questions in the book, the answers are located in the Exploring Your Management Skill Appendix at the end of the book.

FOR EACH STATEMENT CIRCLE:

- “Y” if you would give the advice to Buchanan.
- “N” if you would NOT give the advice to Buchanan.
- “NI” if you have no idea whether you would give the advice to Buchanan.

Mr. Buchanan, in meeting your communication challenges at Jetstar, you should...

Before After
Study Study

1. communicate as well as lead and plan to exercise the influencing management functions.
Y, N, NI
2. be aware of your own emotions as well as the emotions of others in trying to influence people.
Y, N, NI
3. keep in mind that sometimes the primary goal of your communication is simply to share information with other employees.
Y, N, NI
4. decode a message and then send it to Jetstar employees.
Y, N, NI
5. think of yourself as a source/encoder who projects a message signal to a decoder destination.
Y, N, NI
6. be careful not to overload Jetstar employees with information that’s too complex.
Y, N, NI
7. ensure that you don’t use words in your messages that have too many meanings.
Y, N, NI
8. consider field of experience in attempting to communicate successfully.
Y, N, NI
9. not be concerned that your view of the Jetstar employee with whom you’re communicating can affect your messages to that individual.
Y, N, NI
10. keep in mind that interpersonal communication is essentially the same as organizational communication.
Y, N, NI
11. use serial transmissions to avoid communication breakdowns.
Y, N, NI
12. focus on eliminating the grapevine.
Y, N, NI
13. construct communication networks to influence issues such as morale and accuracy of communication.
Y, N, NI
14. remember that your communication effectiveness will probably be affected by your listening ability.
Y, N, NI
15. keep in mind that your informal communication will usually be a detriment to attaining company goals.
Y, N, NI

Exploring Your Management Skill: Part 2

As you recall, you completed Exploring Your Management Skill before you started to study this chapter. Your responses gave you an idea of how much you initially knew about communication and helped you focus on important points as you studied the chapter. Answer the Exploring Your Management Skill questions again now and compare your score to the first time you took it. This comparison will give you an idea of how much you have learned from studying this chapter and

pinpoint areas for further clarification before you start studying the next chapter. Record your answers within the text or go to MyManagementLab.com. Recording your answers in MyManagementLab will allow you to get immediate results and see how your score compares to your classmates. If you answer the questions in the book, the answers are located in the Exploring Your Management Skill section at the end of the book.

Your Management Skills Portfolio

Your Management Learning Portfolio is a collection of activities especially designed to demonstrate your management knowledge and skill. By completing these activities online at MyManagementLab.com, you will be able to print, complete with cover sheet, as many activities as you choose. Be sure to save your work. Taking your printed portfolio to an employment interview could be helpful in obtaining a job.

The portfolio activity for this chapter is Developing a New Communication Environment.⁵⁰ Read the highlight about Ericsson and answer the questions that follow.

Ericsson, headquartered in Stockholm, Sweden, is a world-leading provider of telecommunications equipment with more than 1,000 networks in 140 countries. Forty percent of all mobile calls are made through Ericsson's systems. Ericsson has about 63,000 employees and is one of a few companies that offer worldwide solutions for all major mobile communication networks. A recent joint venture with Sony enabled Ericsson to offer a wide range of mobile devices, including cell phones and related equipment. The company's portfolio containing more than 20,000 patents is evidence of successful research efforts and its goal to be on the cutting edge of technology.

Over the years, Ericsson has invested heavily in maintaining its internal communication. Traditionally, the majority of this investment has been in the area of print and electronic publishing devices. Recently, management indicated that this historical investment approach for maintaining internal communications is no longer appropriate because it no longer meets Ericsson's ambitions for global best practice in all areas of the business. As part of rebuilding internal communications, all the publishing activities were outsourced to an external agency. A new area for significant investment in management's program was to improve internal communications by improving managers' interpersonal communication skills. Further, management wants the company's communication environment to change from an environment where internal communication was more focused on news flow, to an environment where the communication focuses on helping management achieve organizational goals.

Assuming you have the primary responsibility at Ericsson for building this new communication environment, answer the following questions.

What four goals would you set for building the new communication environment at Ericsson?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Explain what each goal contributes toward establishing the new environment that supports reaching organizational goals.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

List a primary step you would take in trying to achieve each goal.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

How long do you think it would take to establish the new communication environment at Ericsson? Why? Explain fully.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Experiential Exercises

1 Developing Nonverbal Communication Skills

Directions. Read the following scenario and then perform the listed activities. Your instructor may want you to perform the activities as an individual or within groups. Follow all of your instructor's directions carefully.

The purpose of this exercise is to help you develop your nonverbal communication skills. Apply yourself as much as possible. The more you focus on the exercise, the greater your chance of developing your skill.

Procedure

1. Your instructor will divide the class into groups of approximately four members.
2. Each group will have about 10 minutes to complete the following task through a group discussion:
List as many advantages and disadvantages as you can to allowing illegal aliens or undocumented workers to remain in the United States.
3. Before discussion begins, each group will be given approximately five minutes so that *members can work individually* to (a) list two feelings they would like to project during the group discussion, and (b) list corresponding nonverbal actions they will use to express those feelings. For example, one feeling might be anger and the related nonverbal action could be yelling words. Individual should *NOT* share their work with other group members.
4. Once members have finished their individual work in number 3, the instructor will signal for group discussion to begin.

5. After the discussion, the instructor will allow each group about five minutes so that individuals can tell what feelings they think other individuals were trying to communicate. All should keep track of how many times their nonverbal messages were successful in communicating their target feelings.
6. The instructor will open discussion about the exercise by asking questions such as the following:
 - a. Were you successful in communicating nonverbally? Why?
 - b. Is it easy for you to communicate nonverbally? Why?
 - c. What did you learn from this exercise about increasing your managerial skill to communicate nonverbally?

2 You and Your Career⁵¹

John Black is a production supervisor in a low-tech toy company that produces wooden cars and boats for children 2–4 years of age. John supervises 25 employees and has been performing well in this same job for five years. In personal reflection, John wants to be promoted, but doesn't think he'll be offered a promotion in the foreseeable future. John doesn't really understand why, however. John has 24/7 e-mail access and is "always on" via his wireless technology. In fact, John is somewhat of a legend at the company for always being on his BlackBerry. John not only has conversations through his BlackBerry, but does quite a bit of message texting. John has always believed that because of the efficiency involved, electronic means of communication are better than face-to-face communication.

Can John's personal philosophy about communication affect his career? If yes, why? If no, why not? If you were John, what personal philosophy about communication would you have to maximize not only your job success, but also the success of your career?

VideoNet Exercise

Communication: Zifty.com

Video Highlights

Zifty.com is a pick-up and delivery service in Atlanta, Georgia. Customers place orders via the Zifty.com Web site for food from local restaurants and for DVDs, personal care products, medicines, and so on, stored in the company warehouse. The video features company managers and a delivery driver who discuss Zifty's management and communication styles. The video provides an excellent discussion of organizational communication. Zifty.com has a very informal communication system, which encourages internal information to flow upward as well as downward. The

company also demonstrates a program of excellent customer service based on frequent communication with its customer base.

Discussion Questions

1. Describe the many roles of Zifty.com managers as discussed by Sarah Bellamy and Dylan Kight in the video.
2. How do employees at Zifty.com communicate with each other? Is communication formal or informal? Does information flow only from the top down—from owners to managers to drivers—or does it flow upward as well?
3. Give some examples of how Zifty.com has adapted to customer requests.

Internet Activity

Browse the Zifty.com site at www.zifty.com. Look at the services offered. Browse the delivery or pick-up section of the site. Check out the FAQs. What do you think of the Zifty.com business model? Is this a service that will attract new customers? Managers at Zifty.com believe they still have growth potential in

the Atlanta market. They feel people in that area are willing to pay a premium price for delivery because, after enduring the long commute home, customers prefer having items delivered instead of venturing out again themselves. What do you think of Zifty.com's outlook for growth and for the future?

CASES

1 JETSTAR AIRWAYS SOARS ON COMMUNICATION

"Jetstar Airways Soars on Communication" (p. 345) and its related Challenge Case Summary were written to help you better understand the management concepts contained in this chapter. Answer the following discussion questions about the Challenge Case to better see how your understanding of influencing and communication can be applied in a company like Jetstar.

1. List three problems that could be caused at Jetstar if Buchanan happened to be a poor communicator.
2. Explain how the problems you listed in number 1 can be caused by Buchanan's inability to communicate.
3. Assuming that Buchanan is a good communicator, discuss three ways he is positively affecting Jetstar as a result of this communication expertise.

2 HOW EBAY STAYS CONNECTED TO ITS COMMUNITY

Read the case and answer the questions that follow. Studying this case will help you better see how your understanding of influencing and communication can be applied in a company such as eBay.

Staying in touch with a worldwide community of 114 million buyers and sellers is all in a day's work for eBay CEO Meg Whitman. When she joined eBay in 1998, it employed fewer than 100 people; today, the San Jose-based company employs 6,300 people and auctions \$24 billion worth of merchandise annually. From clothing to cars to computers, eBay auctions a diverse mix of 29 million items daily on its sites in the Americas, Europe, and Asia. In this fast-paced environment, far-flung employees, managers, buyers, and sellers routinely communicate using their keyboards rather than by talking things over in person.

Fresh from management jobs at Walt Disney, Hasbro, Stride-Rite, and other big corporations, Whitman was both amazed and impressed by the reaction of eBay users she met soon after becoming CEO. "Their passion for eBay [good and bad] was nothing I'd ever seen in 20 years of business," she remembers. This vivid introduction to the eBay community helped shape her approach to influencing and communication.

First, Whitman listens carefully and respectfully before responding. Each morning, she chats with staff members in the cubicles surrounding her own before she logs on to read and then answer e-mail from traders. Every few hours, she checks eBay's message boards to get a sense of what's going on in the community. And after auctioning furniture and other possessions on her company's site, she insists that other eBay executives auction items to gain firsthand knowledge of the experience and learn to appreciate the user's perspective.

Second, the CEO and her colleagues pay close attention to feedback. For example, only after surveying 50,000 users and finding that 80 percent approved did management move ahead with a proposed change to the customizable features of its My eBay page. Although sellers in particular are quick to criticize changes that might impair auction activity or confuse buyers, "most of these sellers know more about eBay than most [eBay] employees," acknowledges Whitman. "They use it every single day. They're the experts." Still, she and her team can't always predict how a particular change will strike the community. Not long ago, Whitman heard from thousands of users complaining about a new enhancement to the eBay site. "That week, I probably got a total of 3,000 or 4,000 e-mails from pottery and glass sellers saying, 'My business is down. You've done the wrong thing,'" she says. Her response? "We fixed it. We rolled back the changes."

Third, Whitman proves through her actions that she understands what eBay really means to its users. In 1999, when technical glitches crashed the site for 22 hours and then caused intermittent problems for several weeks afterward, the CEO drove to the office at 4 A.M. on the first morning trouble erupted. She knew little about hardware and software, yet she stayed and brainstormed solutions day and night with employees and vendors. Whitman explains: "I did the only thing I knew how to do—be there. If I was there, then the best people from the vendors would be there." Looking back, the CEO of Sun Microsystems (which supplies eBay with servers) observed that Whitman "has an amazing velvet-glove touch. Instead of making me angry, she made me want to do just about anything we could to solve her problem. And that's what we did."

Once this crisis was resolved, the CEO shuffled tech management and set tough new standards to prevent similar problems in the future. Now eBay is known around the world for the reliability of its operations, with the site unavailable for just a few seconds during an average month. Small wonder that Whitman receives loud applause when she appears at the company's annual member conference. "I have one of the best jobs in corporate America," she says. "It's this unique blend of commerce and community. The community of users is endlessly interesting and endlessly surprising. That's what I love the most."

QUESTIONS

1. What macrobarriers and microbarriers might hinder successful communication between Meg Whitman and eBay users? What do you suggest she do to address these potential barriers?
2. Do you think the channels of communication in an online business such as eBay differ from those in a traditional business? Explain.
3. How would you recommend new managers at eBay establish rapport with buyers and sellers?

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Exploring Your Management Skill Answers

Chapter 1

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Chapter 3

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Chapter 10

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Chapter 11

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Chapter 12

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Chapter 13

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Chapter 14

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Chapter 15

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Chapter 16

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Chapter 17

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Chapter 18

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Chapter 19

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Chapter 20

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Chapter 21

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Chapter 22

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